

tIme for a chat

Are instant messengers productive or disruptive in the workplace? **Anil Patrick R.** chats with industry representatives to get their take on the issue

Instant Messengers can increase the productivity levels in the workplace tremendously. They provide fast and almost instantaneous two-way communication between people, unlike e-mail.

This advantage of Instant Messengers is a great boon, especially for organisations like

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tages in my opinion is the conferencing facility, which allows any number of users to attend a specific online meeting.

Now take a moment to think of the traditional telephone board system used in most offices. At the most you can get two or three people at the same time in the conference facility provided by these. On the other hand, if an Instant Messenger is used, I can have a meeting with any number of

Instant Messengers (IMs) are a major cause of waste of time and resources as they tend to induce employees to waste time chatting, especially for personal purposes. In our call centre, employee productivity is very closely monitored and disciplined to ensure maximum productivity. For this to happen, we try to ensure that office productivity is not degraded due to people using the Internet for all kinds of

such cyber crimes, which can get the company into trouble. There have been several instances in the US where people have used the Internet access from their offices as a staging area to conduct all kinds of malicious attacks on Web sites or even individuals. Now that cyber laws have come

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“A lot of features that are now available in IMs eat into precious WAN bandwidth”



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ours with offices spread all over India as well as abroad. In our case, we have over six offices at various parts of India. Most of the time we prefer Instant Messengers for interaction between these offices. It’s a great way to cut down costs and increase the speed of communication. We already have 24-hour Internet connectivity at our offices. This makes it all the more sensible to use Instant Messengers for communication.

Compared to conventional methods of communication such as telephone lines, Instant Messengers have several advantages. One of the main advantages

colleagues from all over the world, at one time.

Apart from using Instant Messengers for intra office communication, we also use them to communicate with our alliance partners. We often have to do file transfers for various purposes. The file sharing mechanism in most of the Instant Messengers is very useful for this purpose.

All these advantages have made Instant Messengers an integral part of our work culture. They do help in improving productivity levels since communication is vital for the success of any organisation. ■

non-business uses.

A lot of features that are now available in IMs, such as voice and video chat, and file transfers, lead to misuse of available resources such as bandwidth. While the basic text chat feature of an IM does not hog significant bandwidth, the newer features now available can surely start eating into precious WAN bandwidth, which may be required for other mission-critical business applications.

Yet another danger of the use of IMs is the possibility of employees indulging in online harassment of people and other

into effect in India, it is up to companies to guard against misuse of online resources, lest they get caught up in legal issues.

IMs can allow a disgruntled employee to send confidential data over the Internet, causing loss of proprietary information. It’s also well known that most commercially available messengers have security problems, which could allow crackers access to office networks. The best way to avoid such attacks on your network is to simply rule out such problematic and insecure software applications. ■

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